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Culture (OWC): [Amhara \(MP05\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1967-1969

Coverage Date: 1960s

Place Coverage: Manz District, Shoa Province, Ethiopia

Section Title(S): The Ethnographic Locus And Background

The personality of the *zar* spirit is conceived as a jealous, possessive, demanding, and punishing superhuman being which makes itself known daily and requires tribute daily in order to satisfy its "hunger." Although this "hunger" is most often satisfied with an offering of food, it is more of a symbolic hunger; a hunger for remembrance; a need to be kept alive through ritual acts. The *zar* offering is often seen as a sort of "protection" paid to keep one from misfortune. The daily coffee party, called *tirtib*, is the institutionalized expression of the *zar* tribute where coffee and sugar are offered to it. If too much of the day passes without *tirtib* one will begin to feel an uneasiness, a malaise, which is interpreted as the *zar*'s subtle hint that something, someone, has been forgotten. Among the peasantry the *zar* is discussed only with some apprehension, often masked by joking or humor, because, like true Amhara, the *zar* does not like to be the object of discussion. It can become suspicious and angry and overreact with punishment the way an angry father or mother may punish a child too severely while enraged by the child's misdemeanor.

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Just as there are both male and female saints, so there are *zar* spirits of both sexes. The female *zar* are called *[unknown]celley*. (This term actually refers to a string of blue and white beads kept in a little basket in honor of the female *zar*.) Although these primarily watch over and punish women, they are referred to as the "family *zar*" because a wife and mother is conceived as being the centripetal force and center of family life. Both male and female *zar* spirits have about equal power (which is similar to humans when the spouses are of relatively equal wealth), however, special tribute for the male *zar* spirits is given at the same time as that for the lesser saints, while special tribute to the female *zar* spirits is given on the most important Christian holidays. While the saints are honored publically, the *zar* spirits are honored secretly; a reflection of the value of secrecy in maintaining the system of diadic ties among various patron-client relationships.

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The organization of *zar* spirits parallels Amhara social organization, especially regarding the formal hierarchy of authority. There exists a pyramidal organization of arch *zars*. Each arch *zar* has in its charge an army of lesser *zars*; each army assigned to perform a specific task, ranging from causing a toothache to causing infertility to striking one ill with a dread disease. The higher *zar* spirits protect and oversee the lives of the higher men, lords, government officials, etc., while the lower order *zars* watch over people with respectively lower rank and wealth. In this way the *zar* spirit world oversees and exacts tribute from mortals similar to a father's exacting tribute and service from his children and a lord's exacting tribute and service from his subjects.

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Not everyone has their own personal *zar* spirit. This spirit is inherited through a parent's line of descent after a parent's death. A parent's *zar* is 32 passed on to the eldest offspring. Therefore, the other offspring do not acquire one. Usually, the son will inherit the father's *zar*, provided the father had one and the son is the eldest, and the eldest daughter will inherit her mother's *zar*, provided she had one. If an eldest son's father had no *zar*, but his mother did, upon her death the son will inherit her *[unknown]celley*. Thus, the pattern of the *zar* legacy follows that of an ambilineal primogeniture. It is always the eldest of each generation who receives the *zar* spirit. Therefore, when a father dies the *zar* goes to his eldest son, and if that son dies, the *zar* then must go to the first grandson. The *[unknown]celley* goes from mother to eldest daughter to first granddaughter.

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